Ambassador Pickring. Many have suggested there needs to be stronger Federal control in this area. I believe they are right but I do not believe that that is going to be an easy or simple proposition.

Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

[The prepared statement of Mr. Pickering follows:]

Prepared Statement of the Honorable Thomas R. Pickering, Vice Chairman, Hills & Company (Former United States Ambassador to the United Nations)

Mr. Chairman and Members of the Committee:

It is an honor to appear before you today to address one of the most pressing and emergent issues we face as a nation. One which for too long has been hidden by our focus and concentration on other issues in the region and beyond.

In recognition of the growing crisis in Afghanistan and its relationship to Pakistan, three major American organizations each carried out studies of what was happening and what needs to be done to deal with the problems. It is no accident that the issue is so exigent that when the three organizations gathered to discuss their reports, they immediately agreed to issue their reports together and to join forces in their presentations. That was done on January 30, 2008.

Today's hearing gives me a chance to highlight aspects of the report I had the welcome pleasure of co-chairing with General James Jones, former NATO SACEUR and US Combatant Commander in Europe.

My task is a simple one. In order to highlight the urgency and the importance of the issue I want to present you a summary of the reports key conclusions on what is happening in Afghanistan. Secondly, I want to provide you with the most important recommendations of a distinguished group of panel members each one of whom has had extensive experience in Afghanistan or Pakistan and the region. I don't claim special knowledge or experience in these two significant countries and have relied heavily on the team's expertise and outside experts to make and justify both our conclusions and recommendations. I will draw directly in many cases on the wording of the report to make sure that its points are clearly and crisply conveyed to you.

ASSESSMENT

Afghanistan is at a critical crossroads. Six years of progress is under serious threat from resurgent violence, weakening international resolve, mounting regional challenges and a growing lack of confidence on the part of the Afghan people.

The US and the international community have tried to win the struggle with too few military, insufficient economic aid, and without a clear and consistent strategy. We must now deal with reconstituted Taliban and al Qa'eda forces in Afghanistan and Pakistan, a runaway opium economy and the severe poverty faced by most Afghans.

Why is this so important to us? In the words of our report, success in Afghanistan is a critical national security imperative. Failure means new threats from the Taliban and al

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